The largest Cuban commitment in the 1970s and 80s was in Angola, where the leftist MPLA liberation movement won independence from Portugal in 1975. Cuba sent a force of some 36,000 to help the MPLA repel a South African military invasion encouraged by the United States, and the neighboring struggle of Namibia for independence from South Africa. Cuban military presence in Angola grew to some 52,000 troops by 1988. The Cubans also sent some 16,000 troops to support Ethiopia in early 1978, when the country was invaded by Somalia. Cuban forces helped protect Mozambican ports and oil facilities from attacks by South African-supported rebels in the late 1970s and through the 1980s. And Cuba established smaller military missions (numbering in the hundreds of troops) in the Republic of the Congo, Guinea, Guinea-Bissau, and Benin.[28]

In Latin America, Cuba has lent varying degrees of support to revolutionary movements and leftist governments. In late 1960, after the Río Treaty member states, under U.S. urging, passed the Declaration of San José implicitly condemning Cuba's Revolution, Cuba responded with the First Declaration of Havana announcing its support for hemisphere-wide revolution. Che Guevara's attempt to foment revolution in Bolivia in the mid-1960s was a disaster, ending with his capture and murder by Bolivian forces aided by the CIA in 1967. But Cuba found a strong ally in Chile's socialist President Salvador Allende when he was elected in 1970.

The Sandinista Revolution in Nicaragua owed much to the Cubans. "The Cuban Revolution of 1959 was the critical turning point in [Nicaraguan revolutionary leader Carlos] Fonseca's political evolution," writes his biographer, "opening up the possibility of a deep-going social revolution in his own country, turning him to a study of Sandino's history, and leading directly to the formation of the FSLN."[29] It was in Havana that Fonseca first learned about Augusto César Sandino's uprising against the U.S. occupation of Nicaragua in the 1920s, and began to write and organize, becoming the major theoretician behind the founding of the FSLN in 1962. Nicaraguan priest and liberation theologian Ernesto Cardenal published *En Cuba* describing his experiences there in 1970.